

Key Assumptions Check: The 2002 DC Sniper Case

The outbreak of sniper shootings in the Washington, DC area in the fall of 2002 provides a good example of how this technique could have been applied. After the initial flurry of shootings, the operating assumption that quickly emerged was that the shootings were the work of a single, white male who had some military training and was driving a white van. If law enforcement officials had conducted a Key Assumptions Check, they could have broken this statement into its key components and assessed the validity of each statement as follows:

Key Assumption	Assessment
The sniper is a male.	Highly likely (but not certain) given past precedent with serial killers. We are taking little risk by not looking for a female.
The sniper is acting alone.	Highly likely (but not certain) given past precedents.
The sniper is white.	Likely, but not as certain, given past precedents. We would be taking some risk if we rule out nonwhites as suspects.
The sniper has military training/experience.	Possible, but not sufficient reason to exclude from consideration potential suspects who have not had any military training.
The sniper is driving a white van.	Possible because you have a credible eyewitness account but worthy of continuing scrutiny given the number of white vans in the area (more than 70,000 registered in the Maryland suburbs of Metropolitan Washington, DC) and that different kinds of vehicles are being described.

A Key Assumptions Check could have allowed law enforcement officials to:

- Avoid jumping to conclusions (the sniper is white, has military training, and is driving a white van) that did not hold up under closer scrutiny. By explicitly examining each assumption, officials could have avoided prematurely narrowing down the potential pool of suspects to a group that did not include the actual perpetrator. Similarly, they might have been more cautious about accepting that the sniper was driving a white van.
- Be receptive to new leads and citizen tips, such as eyewitness reports that the sniper fled the scene driving a specific model Chevrolet.
- More seriously consider evidence that subsequently became available, which contradicted a key assumption. If officials had stated explicitly that they were assuming the sniper was acting alone, they might have been sensitive to new information that contradicted that key assumption. Often this type of information gets “lost in the noise” if the analyst has not already thought about what key assumptions he or she is making.